A girl called Margot

On 14 December 1949, two days after arriving in Moscow with a delegation to celebrate Stalin's 70th birthday, Erich Honecker embarked on his first serious love affair with Margot Feist, one of the brightest young stars in the FDJ. Margot was short, she had a bun of brunette hair, fair skin and high cheekbones – and uncorked a stream of passion that he found impossible to resist. 'Margot first fascinated me because she was a pretty young girl,' Honecker recalled. 'Second, I was fascinated by the fact that she was also very active in the party.' Feist's biographer, Ed Stuhler, said she was 'lively, fun and had an infectious loud laugh'. He described a wild, impromptu affair, very spur-of-the-moment, which quickly took a different course. 'It has often been said that Margot got involved with Erich primarily to advance her career in this way,' Stuhler explained. 'But that's nonsense because at that time it was a great risk to enter such a relationship. The affair was extremely risky for Honecker because it violated the party's moral standards. But to be with Margot, he was willing to pay almost any price.' Born on 17 April 1927 in Halle, Margot was a fellow-spirit, having endured a childhood marked by poverty and struggle. Her father (a cobbler) and mother (a factory worker) were both members of the KPD and held onto their convictions after 1933, bringing her father to various prisons and concentration camps.

During their time in Moscow, the young lovers enjoyed Stalin's birthday junket – they attended the Bolshoi, where Erich watched – open-mouthed – as a crowd converged on stage. 'In the middle was Stalin! Then came Mao Tse Tung. I can still remember that the representative of the People's Republic of Poland first gave his good wishes in Russian,' he marvelled. 'The 70th birthday of Stalin was a historic moment, just as the foundation of the German Democratic Republic and the foundation of the People's Republic of China had been.'1

There was an aura of guilt about Honecker when he returned home to Edith and Erica in Berlin. At first, he tried to hide the romance but couldn't resist